After rounds of meetings, Aung Min managed to secure the president's agreement and NDSC decisions for federal system discussions at peace talks. The key point raised by the chief negotiator to the president and to NDSC members was "to accept the'federal union' idea first; while leaving the federal army issue aside" (interview with NDSC member, 14 August 2014). If not, this issue would remain the major obstacle and would stall the peace talks. With endorsement from the NDSC, the Tatmadaw pledged to discuss the issue ahead of a nationwide ceasefire agreement, without compromising its position on the federal army demand. It was the first time in the history of the Tatmadaw that it officially agreed to discuss a federal system with the EAGs.

Although the peace technical team was unable to settle the debate on federalism, it dealt with the need for discussions on a federal system of government. Resolving one issue at a time, it formally bound key stakeholders to the peace process. The piecemeal agreement allowed the Tatmadaw to commit to the peace process while providing opportunities to remedy grievances if necessary. It therefore reduced the Tatmadaw's concerns over possible significant losses from far-reaching decisions, which are harder to alter in future. On the other hand, a formal commitment by the government and Tatmadaw reduced strains on EAGs over their long-standing demands for a federal system, although the "federal army" issue was not solved at the same time. For the EAGs, the agreement has been a remarkable achievement for their participation in the state-initiated peace process. Therefore, both the Tatmadaw and the EAGs adhered to the peace process despite its constraints.

Informal binding

Although formal binding is essential for legitimate negotiations, informal binding should not be underestimated in complex negotiations. To deal with complex issues, which fall under formally restricted areas, policy actors engage in self-enforcing binding activities. These sometimes require them to work outside formal boundaries. Christiansen and Neuhold (2012) explain that establishing informal binding increases efficiency as it could ease decision-making or facilitate negotiations. It serves as a mechanism to cope with obstacles to the complex policy process gradually, especially in a situation where formal binding is not likely to be achieved. Decision-